

HISTORY



THE STUDY OF HISTORY is an attempt by people today to understand the lives of people in the past. Historians – the people who study history – look at primary sources – those writings and artefacts that have survived – and try to piece together a realistic picture of life in previous years. But not every piece of historical evidence survives to the present day, and that which does survive can sometimes be interpreted in many different ways. As a result, history is a complex and sometimes controversial subject that excites considerable debate among historians and non-historians alike.



Meroë pyramid,
Sudan

Sources of history

What we know of history is based on material evidence, such as buildings, roads, tools, artworks, and clothes; written evidence, such as books; and oral evidence handed down through generations. All these sources provide valuable information about past societies and the people who created them.

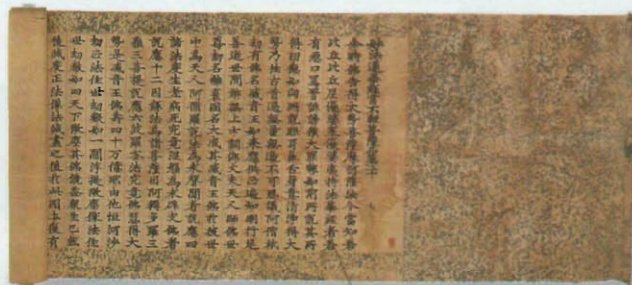
Material evidence

By piecing together material evidence, historians can discover much about the people of the time. The Bayeux Tapestry is the record of a known historical event – the Norman invasion of England (1066). But when historians study it more closely, they discover a wealth of information, not just about the event the tapestry is relating, but about life of the time generally – and even about the women who made the tapestry.

Normans attack the English, Bayeux Tapestry

English soldiers

Norman knights

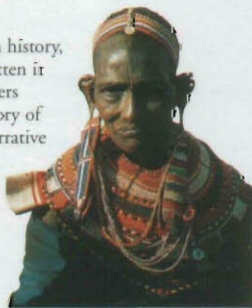


Chinese letter, written on a scroll

The larger the document, the more useful it is to a historian.

Oral history

Many societies know their own history, even though they have not written it down. In West Africa, storytellers known as *griots* record the history of their tribes through lengthy narrative stories set to music. In the 1960s and 1970s, there was a move towards sociological history, whereby historians recorded the stories of people previously left out of historical record-making, such as women and the working classes.



Warrior's mother, Kenya



Parasaurolophus
skull, a type of
duckbill dinosaur

Prehistory

Writing has existed for around 5,500 years. The period before written records is called prehistory. Archaeologists study material evidence, such as bones, fossils, and artefacts, to help them understand prehistoric periods, such as the Stone Age.

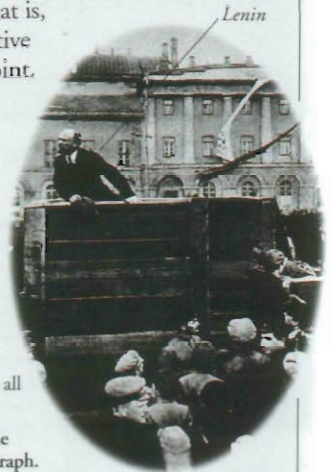
Records of history

All primary sources, whether photographic or written, need careful study, because they may be biased, that is, illustrate a subjective (personal) viewpoint.

Propaganda

Historical evidence may be altered to serve political needs. The Soviet Union saw a power struggle between Josef Stalin (1879–1953) and Leon Trotsky (1879–1940) after the death of Lenin. When Stalin became leader, he had Trotsky removed from all official photographs.

Trotsky appeared in the original of this photograph.



Dark Ages

Historians often label historical periods, though people of the time may not have agreed with the label. The chaotic period in Europe after the Roman Empire fell (c.500) is often called the Dark Ages, yet in places it was a time of culture and learning.

The Book of Durrow, c.800



EP Thompson

Edward Thompson (1924–93) was an important English social historian. His best-known work, *The Making of the English Working Class* (1965) studied the politics and protests of ordinary people as opposed to the history of political leaders.



Timeline

c.400s BC Herodotus writes history of the Greek–Persian wars.

c.800 Monks begin the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle.

1380s Arab historian Ibn Khaldun writes *Kitab al-Ibar*, to explain why civilizations rise and fall.

1800s History established as an academic subject, with the emphasis on primary sources, rather than interpretation.

1860s Karl Marx (1818–83) argues a view of history in which economic factors determine events.

1930s French historians of the Annales school concentrate on social history.

1960s Historians focus on people previously ignored in accounts of history, such as women.

1992 US historian Frances Fukuyama argues that the fall of communism "ended" history.



Ammonite, prehistoric material evidence

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